

Episode 200: About *Revolutionary Girl Utena* – Part 2

With November's arrival, several of my jobs for next year have been cleared for information release.

First is *Witch Craft Works*. Director is Mizushima Tsutomu. J.C.Staff production. My credit for this work is "Visual Coordinate." It's a title for my project that I've been developing since last year to tackle work creation one step beyond colour design. I'll write about this here sometime. And colour design is by Ishida Miyuki from *Dream Eater Merry* and *The Pet Girl of Sakurasou*.

Another is *Wake Up, Girls!* Director is Yamakan - Director Yamamoto Yutaka. Production is Tatsunoko + ordet. With Director Yamamoto this is the third work following *blossom* and *The Miyakawa Family's Hunger*. I'm participating as colour design. *WUG* has both theatrical work opening at year-end starting with Sendai and TV series in operation. Both start airing from January.

And Director Sato Junichi's OVA *Critically Endangered Girl: Amazing Twins*. This also releases in January.

Working hard like that! Please look forward to it! Thank you!

Now then.

Following Ikuhara and Hasegawa, Kaneko, Nagahama, and Takahashi began entering BE-PAPAS studio, and gradually the *Revolutionary Girl Utena* site was getting organised.

As for me, I commuted to the studio about once every three weeks (?). In my case, participating in *Utena* didn't mean quitting Toei Animation, but rather doing Toei Animation work fully as before while doing *Utena*-related work on weekends or late at night and such. Basic home work. Gradually bringing compiled results step by step, attending meetings at such a pace.

My work was making character colour images concrete. After grasping rough colour images shown in meetings with Ikuhara and Hasegawa, and colour restrictions arising from story and character settings, I'd concretely add colours to character settings.

In most animation character colour creation, the process is: character design gets OK → clean up character settings → begin colour work (create colour samples with cel animation). But *Utena*'s approach was to not decide line art design first, but decide design including colour.

While Hasegawa would draw based on Saito Chiho's character rough drafts, actually the story wasn't a solid final version yet either - it was still a period of subtle fluctuation. So character setting directions weren't fully solidified, and character settings were still at the rough stage.

So I'd add colours to settings at that stage, but how to do this work? I didn't want to start making colour samples using cel paints from the beginning. As I wrote earlier, since *Utena* was home work for me, first doing cel colouring at home was super troublesome. Setting up cel paints, light boxes, drying racks - all that stuff would be a major undertaking.

Moreover, if you start thinking with cel paints from the beginning, you get restricted by paint colour numbers and types, potentially shackling your ideas.

Furthermore, the problem of which manufacturer's paints to use. STAC or Taiyo Shikisai? Well, since it wasn't a Toei work, it would definitely be Taiyo Shikisai, and then I didn't have those paints on hand... and so on.

Now I'd start like "well, let's scan line art into computer..." but it was 1995. While personal computers were gradually becoming usable in video and image fields, casually

importing images and adding colours was still far from general use. Anime production sites were still in the analogue era of cel animation supremacy.

So what did I do?

There's an alcohol-based colour pen called "Copic," and I used that to add colours to paper settings for image creation. First I'd copy character settings using slightly good quality copy paper. Then I'd keep painting with Copic in my imagined colour schemes. Well, colouring! This was good! Since it's alcohol-based ink you can layer like transparent watercolour, layering according to shading to create strength and gradation, finishing to look close to printed anime cel paint samples. Actually I jumped on Copic as soon as it came out and saw it at art supply stores, using it considerably for thinking about colours in Toei works from around the year before.

For now I got all available Copic colours and kept adding colours vigorously. Since these were just drafts, I tried many colour sketches of many types from one setting drawing. It's probably past the statute of limitations so I'll write it, but actually that "slightly good quality copy paper" was secretly copied at Toei Animation (ah, sorry (sweat)).

I'd take those coloured settings to BE-PAPAS. We'd spread them on the studio reception set table for opinion exchange with everyone including Ikuhara and Hasegawa. Then using scissors right there, we'd cut up the settings I'd coloured for collage. This hair colour, this outfit, but maybe this colour division is better for the outfit? Like that. Furthermore, while doing that, "Should we add lines here to enable colour division?" or "Maybe there should be something as a focal point on the shoulder part" - we'd change design along with colours.

Hasegawa would create new rough drawings of ideas that emerged, I'd add colours to those again and bring them, everyone would give opinions again, and sometimes we'd return to the previous design (laugh). We repeated such exchanges many, many times. Among such back-and-forth, Tougo's hair mesh and the student council's asymmetrical uniform colour divisions were decided.

We continued such exchanges from 1995 into 1996. During that time I participated in *Dragon Ball* theatrical versions, did *Sailor Moon S* and *SS* theatrical versions - as always busy with Toei work, and during those busy periods *Utena* work would stop. But *Utena*'s broadcast start was finally looking like spring 1997. Then decision work would have to proceed all at once.

(13.11.15)